Transformation Design Project Module

Project Docket 2026

Module dates: 8th October – 18th December 2026

A lot of what you'll draw on here isn't new to you. The community projects you did in your first year, sitting with people, observing before assuming, holding ambiguity instead of rushing to a solution, are exactly the instincts this module asks you to bring back, just applied to bigger, messier, more consequential problems. The conversations and values you engaged with at last year's conference matter here too, this module is fundamentally about who you're designing for and why, not just what you're designing.

You'll also pick up two things you haven't formally learned yet: how to map a complex system to find where it can actually be shifted, and how to build a basic theory of change, naming the assumption that links what you design to the outcome you're hoping for. Your faculty mentors will teach you both. Beyond that, expect to learn just as much from the organizations and communities you work with directly, they've been living inside these problems far longer than any of us have, and that firsthand understanding is something no classroom can substitute for.

By the end of the module, every team will have developed a design proposal, presented at a colloquium on 18th December, in front of the partner organizations you've worked with all term. This isn't a mock presentation. The people you're designing for and with will be in the room.

15 live projects, working with organizations and communities. Every one of these is a live problem someone is trying to solve, these are not simulated briefs.

Project names, organizations, and partner identities have been deliberately left out. Choose based on what the work is, the scope, the skills it asks of you, the kind of designer it'll make you practice being.

Read through everything before the open house. You'll select your 5 choices on the preference form, which will be shared on 1st October. The form will open at 11 AM and close at 1 PM. Those who fail to submit their selections will be allocated to a project by the Module Team. No internal shuffling will be entertained, as sections will be created and announced by 6th Oct.

Project 1: Redesigning a child's daily news-reading notebook
Project 2: Auditing a learning product for inclusion
Project 3: Taking a Mumbai classroom idea and making it work in a village
Project 4: Making people trust a strange water machine
Project 5: Concept to Reality, A Café Run by a Transgender Community
Project 6: Livelihood generation for Specially-abled
Project 7: Getting people to show up to court
Project 8: Fixing the silence after someone speaks up to the government
Project 9: Getting the right people to show up to a government consultation
Project 10: Reimagining physical help centres for migrant workers
Project 11: Redesigning vocational training for kids in the justice system
Project 12: Designing a game that helps kids name their emotions
Project 13: Researching how physical space shapes a child's sense of belonging
Project 14: Designing a simulation of the juvenile justice system
Project 15: Making mentoring feel personal
What happens next

Project 1: Redesigning a child's daily news-reading notebook

Seats: 20 | A school in Mumbai; studio-based for most of the term

The organization: A startup that runs a daily 20-minute news-literacy class in schools. Every day, kids read one news story, at their level, and do a short activity, sometimes fact-checking a claim, sometimes figuring out what they'd need to know before believing something. The goal is teaching children to think critically about information at a time when AI makes it easier than ever to fake something.

The problem: Every child gets a random ₹18 notebook from a stationery shop to write in daily. It's not designed for this at all, there's a daily prompt, a weekly quiz, a weekend task meant to build a habit, but the notebook itself does nothing to support any of that rhythm. Same goes for the 20-minute class itself, right now it runs on nothing but a teacher's energy.

What you'll do: Sit in classrooms and watch how a 10-year-old uses this notebook. Talk to the teacher and see which part of the 20-minute class gives them a hard time conducting. Then design a new notebook, and props or routines for the class itself, so both work as one system instead of two different pieces.

Good fit if: You like product, visual and communication design, you're curious about how children behave, and you don't mind spending time in a 5th Grade classroom.

Project 2: Auditing a learning product for inclusion

Seats: 20 | Studio-based, with possible classroom visits

The organization: Same news-literacy startup as Project 1.

The problem: They built this whole daily experience, notebook, classroom screen, 20-minute session, and always meant for it to work for every kind of child. But nobody's ever checked if it works for a child with low vision, colour blindness, a different reading speed, or attention differences, etc. It might be failing children right now and nobody knows.

What you'll do: Investigate first, design second. You'll audit the entire experience through one specific lens (vision, reading level, colour, attention), find gaps, then design fixes that solve what you find.

Good fit if: You're detail-obsessed, curious about accessibility and inclusive design.

Project 3: Taking a Mumbai classroom idea and making it work in a village

Seats: 20 | You find your own site: Kalyan, Ullasnagar, Kamba, or similar areas near campus

The organization: Same news-literacy startup.

The actual problem: Their program works great in one well-funded Mumbai school with a projector, small classes, trained teachers. What happens in a classroom of 70 kids, no projector, three languages spoken at once, and a teacher who's barely been trained?

What you'll do: First, find a school or community group near campus willing to work with you, nobody's handing you contacts, that's part of the job. Then figure out what this program would even need to look like in that setting, and build a plan a future team could pilot.

Good fit if: You're self-driven and don't need a ready-made setup to start, you're comfortable knocking on doors, and you like solving problems that don't have an obvious first move.

Project 4: Making people trust a strange water machine

Seats: 40 | A coastal Maharashtra community

The organization: An environmental research foundation that's built a mobile, solar-powered water treatment unit, it can drive into a village and turn contaminated water clean, no electricity grid, no technician needed.

The actual problem: Water is becoming an increasingly difficult resource for coastal communities. There are different ways of thinking about how freshwater can be accessed, preserved, and made available, but what works in one place may not work in another. The challenge is to understand the relationship between water, place, people, and the systems around them, and explore where design can meaningfully intervene.

What you'll do: Design around existing water systems and the communities that depend on them. You'll explore how traditional freshwater systems can become relevant again, and how the mobile purification technology can work within this larger context. You'll look at how water is accessed, understood, shared, and sustained, and what could make these systems work as part of everyday life.

The fieldwork:
The project involves working directly with coastal communities and understanding the environmental and social conditions that shape freshwater availability. You'll work in groups and can spend 2.5 days in the field as part of the project.

The village visit has a logistics fee of about ₹2,000 per student. It covers accommodation, one meal a day, and local travel during the visit. Not every student needs to go. Your team can nominate someone to do the fieldwork, and the rest of the team can chip in to cover that person's fee. However, there is no cap at how many students can go for the fieldwork.

Good fit if: You care about environmental and social impact, you're okay with fieldwork in a rural setting, and you like designing systems and services.

Project 5: Concept to Reality, A Café Run by a Transgender Community

Seats: 8–10 | Nandurbar district, continuing an existing project

The organization: A district government office, working alongside a community organization.

The actual problem: Last year, a BITS student team designed a full concept for a cafe, business plan, brand, menu, everything, to be run by and for the local transgender community. The government now wants it to be developed and operationalized.

What you'll do: Less "come up with a big idea," more "make an existing idea." You'll work out operations, layout, supply chain, whatever it takes to get a cafe with doors open. You're picking up someone else's work, refining it.

Good fit if: You like practical, hands-on problem-solving over blue-sky concepts, and you take relationships with communities seriously. You are comfortable working with and for this community. You like working in domains of experience, space and system design.

Project 6: Livelihood generation for Specially-abled

Seats: 30–36 | Six government block offices in Nandurbar district

The organization: Same district government office.

The actual problem: Specially-abled community members across six different areas want to start small businesses, a shop, a service, but most of them are just guessing at what'll get approved. A tea stall feels "safe" to ask for. A Xerox shop feels "easy." Nobody’s told them what the government scheme is looking for, so good ideas get rejected and the same few "safe" ideas keep getting repeated.

What you'll do: Learn what the scheme funds and why, talk to community members about what they’re good at and want to do, then help them build a business proposal that's both, aspirational or dream to them and likely to get approved.

Good fit if: You like designing with people, not just for them, and you're patient enough to work through a real government process. Comfort speaking Marathi is needed for this one for at least 1 member in each team.

Project 7: Getting people to show up to court

Seats: ~20 | Mumbai, across multiple lower courts hearing cheque-bounce cases | **Marathi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: A non-profit collective working to redesign how India's dispute resolution systems function, contributing to a national digital courts initiative meant to make the process work better for everyone in it: the litigant, the lawyer, and the judge.

The problem: About 60% of cheque-bounce cases in Indian courts sit pending because the person being sued doesn't show up. Courts burn enormous time and resources on cases that go nowhere because of this one gap.

What you'll do: Work in a team of 4 assigned to one specific court, observing behaviour on court premises and interviewing litigants about what it's like to receive a legal notice and decide whether to respond. Only Marathi-fluent students conduct the direct interviews, so team composition matters here.

Good fit if: You speak Marathi, you're patient with unfamiliar bureaucratic systems, and you're interested in applying design thinking to institutions, not just individual users.

Project 8: Fixing the silence after someone speaks up to the government

Seats: ~6 | Mumbai, CIVIS Office (Fort) | **Hindi fluency preferred for field research**

The organization: A civic-tech platform that lets citizens give feedback on government laws and policies, through a website and WhatsApp.

The problem: Someone submits feedback on a policy that affects them. Then, silence. No confirmation it mattered, no update, no sign anyone read it. People believe in the idea of being consulted, but they rarely see proof it changes anything, so next time, they don't bother.

What you'll do: Map the entire journey, from someone discovering a consultation on WhatsApp or the CIVIS website to submitting feedback to whatever happens after. Interview participants who submitted successfully, and people who started but gave up partway. Design and test better confirmations, outcome updates, and reasons to come back next time.

Good fit if: You're interested in UX and service design, you're good at getting honest answers from people who dropped out of something, and civic tech interests you.

Project 9: Getting the right people to show up to a government consultation

Seats: ~6 | Mumbai, CIVIS Office (Fort) | **Hindi fluency preferred for field research**

The organization: Same civic-tech platform as Project 8.

The problem: Most government consultations barely reach the people they're about. A policy affecting street vendors might get feedback mostly from people who aren't street vendors. The goal is real turnout, especially from the specific people a policy directly affects.

What you'll do: Pick one live consultation. Define who counts as "affected" by it. Interview people who took part and people who never heard it existed. Build an outreach system, through partners, plain-language explainers, WhatsApp, that gets the right voices into the room.

Good fit if: You like strategy and systems thinking, and you're comfortable talking to people who chose not to engage with something, harder than talking to people who did.

Project 10: Reimagining physical help centres for migrant workers

Seats: ~10 | Mumbai | **Hindi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: A worker rights organization running physical support centres for migrant workers across multiple states.

The problem: Imagine needing to negotiate with a landlord, argue with an employer, or walk into a police station, in a language that isn't fully yours, with no paperwork proving how many days you worked. These centres exist to help with exactly that, but translation gaps and missing documentation tools make it far harder than it should be.

What you'll do: Visit a Mumbai centre, work directly with its staff and the workers who come in, and reimagine what it could be, solving translation gaps at real moments, and designing documentation tools that could hold up as proof for a worker's case.

Good fit if: You speak Hindi, and you're interested in space and experience design with a social-justice angle.

Project 11: Redesigning vocational training for kids in the justice system

Seats: ~4 | Mumbai | **Hindi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: A foundation working inside reform centres and children's homes, places built around safety, dignity, and second chances for vulnerable children and young people.

The problem: The vocational training these kids get, carpentry, tailoring, currently feels more like a routine chore than a path toward creativity, skill, or income.

What you'll do: With faculty-vetted, limited-access visits alongside Ashiyana's own staff (open observation isn't possible given the setting), redesign the training so it works as a space for learning, creativity, and enterprise, not just a scheduled activity.

Good fit if: You speak Hindi, you have emotional maturity, and you understand this work needs real care, not a portfolio project involving vulnerable kids.

Project 12: Designing a game that helps kids name their emotions

Seats: ~2 | Mumbai | **Hindi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: Same foundation as Project 11.

The problem: Kids in these institutions often don't have the words for what they're feeling, and without that language, it's hard for them, or the adults around them, to work through it.

What you'll do: With faculty-vetted, limited-access visits alongside Ashiyana staff, design a game or play-based activity that helps kids recognize, distinguish, and communicate a wider range of emotions.

Good fit if: You speak Hindi, you're drawn to game and play design, and you're comfortable with the emotional weight this work carries.

Project 13: Researching how physical space shapes a child's sense of belonging

Seats: ~2 | Mumbai | **Hindi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: Same foundation as Projects 11 and 12.

The problem: The physical spaces these kids live in were built around restriction and control. That shapes how a child sees themselves, as someone being contained, not someone who belongs anywhere.

What you'll do: With faculty-vetted, limited-access visits alongside Ashiyana staff, research how space, its layout, its materials, its rules, could shift that relationship from control toward dignity and belonging.

Good fit if: You speak Hindi, you're interested in the politics of space and the built environment, and you can hold research-first thinking in a sensitive setting.

Project 14: Designing a simulation of the juvenile justice system

Seats: ~2 | Mumbai | **Hindi fluency mandatory for field research**

The organization: Same foundation as Projects 11–13.

The problem: Most people have little understanding of what a child goes through navigating the juvenile justice system. Without that understanding, there's no public empathy, and without empathy, no pressure to improve the system.

What you'll do: With faculty-vetted, limited-access visits alongside Ashiyana staff, design a simulated experience that helps an outside audience understand and empathize with what these kids go through.

Good fit if: You speak Hindi, you're interested in experience design as a tool for empathy-building, and you can handle a heavy subject with care.

Project 15: Making mentoring feel personal

Seats: ~4 | Pune

The organization: An organization working to make sure rights and entitlements people are legally owed reach communities that usually get left out of the system, including a mentoring program for students.

The problem: Mentoring works best when it feels shaped around the specific person being mentored, but mentors currently lack good tools to understand where each student stands in their own journey, and students have little say in shaping the experience themselves.

What you'll do: Explore how technology could make the mentoring experience more engaging, personalized, and student-led, while giving mentors better visibility into each student's individual path.

Good fit if: You're interested in EdTech and service design, and you like designing tools that serve two different users, mentor and student, at once.

What happens next

1. **Join the Teams channel** using this link: General | Transformation Design Project (2026) and ask anything you need to know for you to choose 5 projects you would love to be a part of and work on, questions and answers visible to everyone.
2. **Preference form** opens on **1st October, 11 AM**, closes **1 PM** the same day. Select your 5 choices. Link to the form: Transformation Design Project — Project Preference Form – Fill in form
3. **Allocation** is based on your selections, factoring in language or skill requirements where a project needs them. If you don't submit the form, the Module Team will allocate you to a project.
4. Sections will be created and announced by **6th October**, and no internal shuffling will be entertained after that.